B2 Reading

Reading between the lines: inference

Work out what a writer means but does not say directly, using clues in the text rather than guesses.

Writers don't always state everything. An *inference* is a conclusion you reach from clues in the text. B2 exam questions often ask what the writer *implies* or *suggests*, or how a character probably feels.

Clue	Text	Inference
Actions	*She checked her phone for the tenth time.*	She is anxious or waiting for news.
Word choice	*The so-called "luxury" hotel...*	The writer doesn't think it was luxurious.
What is missing	*The food was fine. The view, however, was spectacular.*	The food was nothing special.
Contrast	*He said he loved the gift and put it in a drawer.*	He probably didn't like it.

Prove it. For every inference, point to the words that support it. If you can't find a clue in the text, it is a guess, not an inference.

Common mistake. Going too far. From *He arrived late again* you can infer he is often late, but not that he is lazy or will lose his job.

Read the text

When Omar opened the envelope, the room went quiet. He read the letter twice, folded it carefully and put it back in his pocket. "Well," he said, looking out of the window, "at least I won't have to move to Riyadh." His mother quietly put the kettle on.

Practice

1. Did Omar get the news he wanted? How do you know?
2. What was the letter probably about?
3. What does "at least" suggest about his feelings?
4. Why might his mother put the kettle on?
5. Can we infer that Omar is angry with his mother? Why or why not?

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Probably not: he reads it twice, looks away and tries to find something positive.
2. A job or university place in Riyadh that he did not get.
3. He is disappointed and is trying to see a small positive side.
4. To comfort him without saying anything.
5. No. There is no clue in the text about anger towards his mother.